Genus and species

BACKGROUND

classification (say 'cla-sif-i-ca-shen') – putting living things into categories so we can be specific and exact in the way we talk about things

We classify living things in groups because they are alike (similar) or unalike (different). Similarities may include the way something moves, what it looks like or how it reproduces. However, animals and plants with the same characteristics or features are only grouped together as a species if they are related genetically. For example, two butterflies may look very much alike, but they may not be closely related. Members of the same species can breed together to produce fertile offspring; if they can't, they are not considered part of the same species.

Writing scientific names

When we write a living thing's scientific name, we include the genus and the species. The genus is the first part of the name and begins with a capital letter and appears in italics. The species comes second and is written in lower case letters and italics.

☞ **1** Rewrite the following species names correctly.

a) panthera Leo _____

b) *equus zebra* _____

c) Balaenoptera Musculu _____

d) Homo *sapiens* _____

e) Macropus *Rufus* _____

f) camelus bactrianus _____

2 The common name of a living thing is the name that people normally use when talking about it. Can you match these common names with the species names from question 1? Share your anwers and try to match them all.

a) mountain zebra _____

b) bactrian camel _____

c) lion _____

d) blue whale _____

e) red kangaroo _____

f) human _____

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